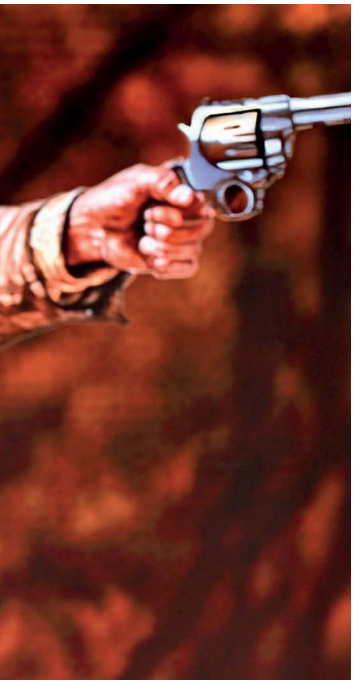


Trump is holding friend and foe alike at gunpoint for a better deal. Geopolitics has turned into reality TV. The old template is cracking and being replaced by a sense of anarchy

benefits. In the near future, artificial intelligence is predicted to surpass human intelligence. They are calling it the Singularity. You can look at this with excitement or trepidation. I have some questions though:

If machines do everything, what will human beings do? Where will the jobs come from? What will be people's source of income? The economy cannot run without consumers. Barbers will probably be the last to lose their jobs! At least I won't ever get my hair cut from an AI-powered robot.

With its human tech resources, India has the potential to be a significant player in the world of AI. The prime minister is cognisant of this and has created a Rs 10,300 crore India AI mission. One of the pioneers of AI, Sam Altman, said on his recent visit to India that India should be one of the leaders of the AI revolution.

Technology also persuades us to think beyond countries. Whether Donald Trump likes it or not, globalisation will remain a driving force for change. We are inextricably connected through supply chains, telecommunications, and even the controversial migration of people. Globalisation has been a force for good and will continue to be so. It's estimated that over 1 billion people have been lifted out of poverty since 1960. This may hit a speed bump with America's current attitude, but its march is inevitable. International trade will just be realigned.

Other technologies that will change and are changing the world are synthetic biology, which involves gene editing, and cryptocurrency based on blockchain. One will change healthcare, and the other will change how economies are managed. Both these technologies are linked to the advancement of AI.

As far as geopolitics is concerned, we are in for some significant changes.

↘ Instead of the USA being the lone superpower, China is emerging as a serious challenger. Currently, one is a Diet Dictatorship, and the other is a full-on one with Xi as president for life. They are rivals, but they need each other. Trump may want to play hardball with China, but he has to remember that they play a long game. If he hands over part of Ukraine to Russia, China may test him and invade Taiwan.

↘ Trump has weakened the trans-Atlantic alliance but united Europe in the process. His cosy relationship with Putin must worry them, though.

↘ India is in a sweet spot. Both America and China would like to be on good terms with us.

PM Narendra Modi has skilfully negotiated these choppy waters by managing the unpredictable Trump. He did his homework by reducing duties on items close to Trump's heart before his American visit, like the Harley-Davidson motorcycles and bourbon whiskey. He is an experienced leader having held high public office for 24 years. India is fortunate to have him on the international stage. Somebody the world takes seriously. Not like a former comedian or reality TV star.

One of the unintended consequences of Trump's policies would be a much-needed aggressive opening up of the Indian economy to the world and deregulation to encourage foreign investment. We always seem to act better when faced with a crisis. And, there's no shortage of crises.

We have climate change, the mother of all crises. And it is accelerating and affecting everything and everyone. And here we have a president of a country that historically has been the worst polluter. And he's in denial. Unless the world acts in concert, it will be a terrible legacy to leave for future generations.

One also has to mention the massive success of the Maha Kumbh, which saw 660 million people visit the city of Prayagraj in 45 days. It was the biggest gathering the world has ever seen. The architect of this spectacular event is the chief minister of Uttar Pradesh, Shri Yogi Adityanath.

Democracy survives only when those in power genuinely believe in democratic values. The checks and balances of institutions work only if those in power respect those values. Consider what Donald Trump is doing in a country with such strong institutions. He's weaponising the investigative agencies and persecuting his rivals. He has put in place people who do his bidding. Unlike his previous term, now he has no guard rails. Also, democracy survives when there is a free flow of truthful information. It is the oxygen of democracy. It is a conversation between the rulers and the ruled. ■

To watch the full session, visit **https://bitly.cx/T07w**